

training at a camp while the Olympics were underway.

Performing like a well-oiled unit, India brushed aside China 3-0, Japan 5-1 and Malaysia 8-1 in its first three league-stage games.

It was Korea that made the Indians sweat for the first time. Quick goals from Araijeet and skipper Harmanpreet Singh made it seem like another one-sided contest was on the cards before the Koreans pulled one back at the stroke of half-time. Harmanpreet restored the two-goal lead in the 43rd minute, but overall, it was a brave effort from Korea as it saw the ball as much as the Indians in terms of possession and also earned more Penalty Corners.

The game against Korea was the perfect appetiser for India's last round-robin match against arch-rival Pakistan, which would decide the league-stage topper.

Pakistan's preparation for the tournament had taken a hit when Roelant Oltmans refused to accept another short-term assignment from its national federation. Olympian Tahir Zaman had to be urgently appointed as the new coach, just four days before the team's opening match against Malaysia.

However, Pakistan, one of the youngest squads, played far better than their last two outings against India — an embarrassing 2-10 loss at the Asian Games and 0-4 defeat at the previous Asian Champions Trophy in Chennai. Here, it even took the lead courtesy of Ahmed Nadeem's strike in the eighth minute. India was guilty of wasting a lot of chances, but Harmanpreet's brace proved enough for a 2-1 win. A glimpse of how fierce the rivalry

is came in the final quarter. Tempers flared when Waheed Ashraf Rana hit Jugraj in the face with his elbow, leading to an inaudible verbal exchange between the players of the two teams. The umpires were forced to separate the two groups. Rana received a 10-minute yellow card for 'serious misconduct'. Compared to the league stage, India had a much easier outing against Korea in the semifinals — a 4-1 victory featuring a hat-trick from Harmanpreet. Host China, the lowest-ranked team in the tournament, had already shocked Pakistan 2-0 in the penalty shootout after a 1-1 draw in the first semifinal.

In the summit clash, China tried to

frustrate India with a low block, and the tactic proved to be largely successful. However, in the 51st minute, Harmanpreet made his way into the shooting circle with an incisive run on the left flank and moved along the baseline before finding Jugraj in front of the goalmouth, who slotted the ball into the bottom-right corner. The goal sealed India's fifth title, the most by any nation. Pakistan, with three, is second.

The 1-0 scoreline does not reveal the extent to which the Indians dominated the final, barring the rare counter-attacks from the host.

While ace drag-flicker Harmanpreet led from the front with seven goals, coach Fulton would have been pleased with the fact that he was well supported by Uttam (4), Raj Kumar Pal (3), Araijeet (3) and Sukhjeet (3) in the scoring department. In Hardik's absence, Abhishek Nain stepped in as the injector during the Penalty Corner routines. India earned 29 PCs — the second-lowest amongst the six teams — but it had a conversion rate of 27.59 per cent, only behind Korea, which was the most successful team at 36.67 per cent.

Krishan and Suraj, who had been Sreejesh's understudies, conceded a total of just five goals through the quarterly rotation which was in place for the tournament.

Fulton could have considered resting more members from the Paris squad and introducing fresh faces, even if it meant risking a few losses. Beating lower-ranked teams does little to improve ranking points. More importantly, giving young players international experience at the start of the new Olympic cycle is crucial, as tougher challenges such as the new season of the FIH Pro League, the Asia Cup in 2025 and the World Cup in 2026 await India.

Harmanpreet Singh has led the Indian men's hockey team with elan. PTI

